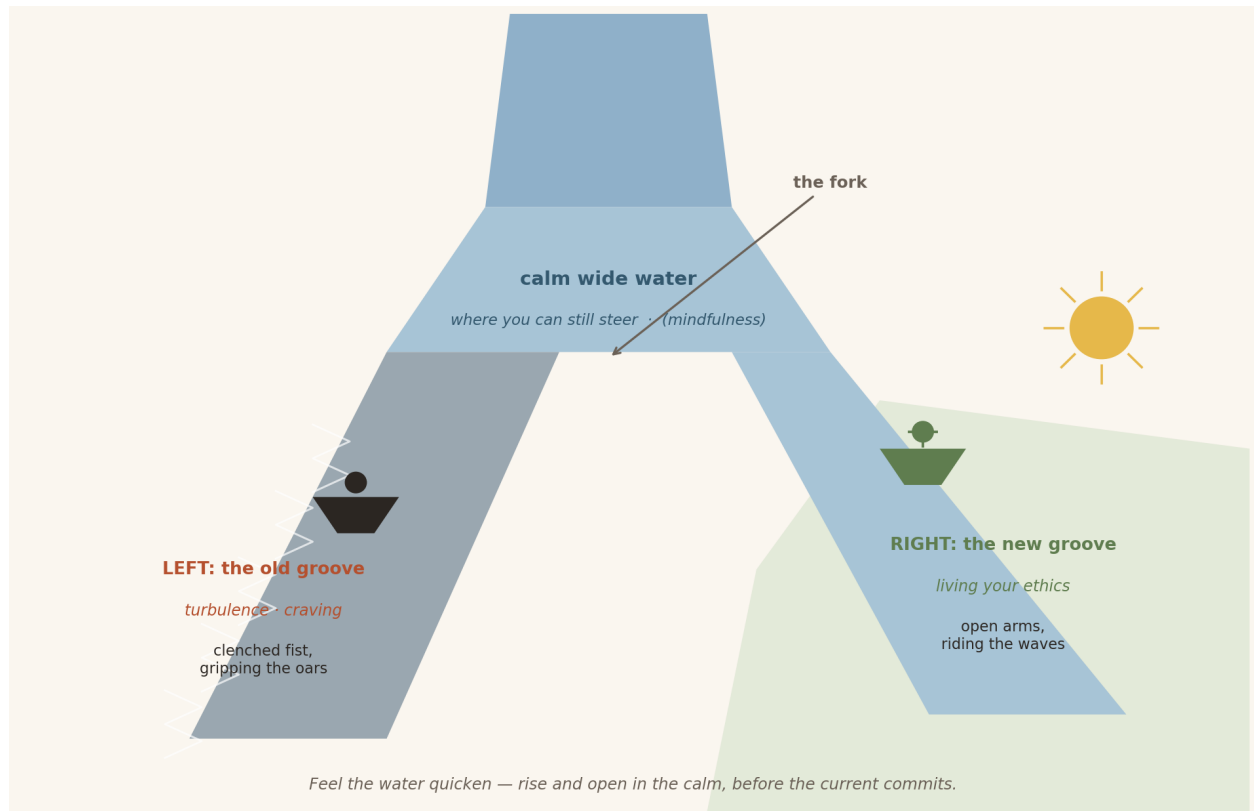


CORE TEACHINGS · A PRACTICE FOR DAILY LIFE

The River

Calm water, the fork, and what to do when life turns turbulent

You are on the river of life. The current has always run one way — down the deep old **groove** worn so long it feels like the only way. This is a picture you can step inside any moment of any day: not an idea to think about, but a place to stand.



Find the calm water before the fork; steer, gently, toward the greener channel.

The calm water, and the fork

When emotion rises and the water turns turbulent, look for the **calm wide stretch** just before the split — that is mindfulness, catching it early, while you can still steer. You can't stand up and open your arms mid-rapid; it's too late there. You rise in the calm water, before the current commits. At the fork, two channels: the worn **left**, and a newer **right**.

LEFT — the old groove

Turbulence, craving. You crouch low, gripping the oars, white-knuckled, bracing against every wave, fighting a river that won't be controlled. The **clenched fist**. The clenching never calms the water — it only exhausts you, and turns every wave into a threat.

RIGHT — the new groove

Living your ethics. You stand, open your arms, face to the sun, and let the boat be carried. The water is calm not because you conquered it but because you stopped fighting it. The **open hand**. Each time you steer here, this channel carves a little deeper, and the old one silts up.

Re-carving the riverbed — gently

You don't carve the new channel by fighting the old one — no damming, no thrashing. You just calmly steer right, again and again. Gentle repetition, not force (remember the lute string: too tight and it snaps). And even on the calm channel, **waves still come**. The open

posture isn't "no waves" — it's meeting each wave by swaying with it instead of bracing. **Grief is the wave; suffering is the bracing against it.**

The self that poofs into being

Watch closely and you'll see the eleventh link happen live. Before the boat, there's just water — current, turbulence — with no one it's happening *to*. Then, **poof**, a self springs into existence in the boat: "this is happening to me, this shouldn't be." The rapids were already there; the self doesn't find the suffering, it **creates the sufferer** that suffering needs. And what can poof into being can poof out: catch your own boat forming, and in that seeing it can quietly dissolve back into just... water.

When there is no calm water

Sometimes life gives no calm stretch to reach. Don't try to paddle back upstream to find it — the water only flows one way, and the wish to be elsewhere is itself a small arrow. Instead, dissolve the boat **right where you are, in the rapids**. The turbulence doesn't need to become calm; the instant the clenching "me" at the centre softens, the rough water has no one left to torment. **Freedom isn't calmer water — it's no one home to be battered by it.**

Memory hooks

- ◆ **Turbulence rising?** Find the calm wide water before the fork — steer while you still can (mindfulness).
- ◆ **Left = fist:** gripping the oars, fighting the waves. **Right = open hand:** standing, arms open, carried.
- ◆ **Steer right, gently, again and again** — the new groove deepens, the old one silts up. Repetition, not force.
- ◆ **Waves still come:** sway, don't brace. Grief is the wave; suffering is the bracing.
- ◆ **No calm water?** Dissolve the boat in the rapids — soften the "me," and there's no one left to suffer.

Review — test yourself

Cover the notes and answer aloud in your own words:

1. Why must you steer in the **calm water** and not in the rapids?
2. Describe the two boat postures — **left** and **right** — and what each stands for.
3. How do you carve the new groove, and what happens to the old one?
4. What's the difference between the **wave** and the **bracing**?
5. When there's no calm water to reach, what is the **deeper move** — and why isn't it 'escape'?

One-line takeaway: *Find the calm water and steer toward the greener channel when you can — and when you can't, let the clenching self dissolve in the rapids, so the rough water becomes just water, with no one left to be battered by it.*